

Breast cancer 'curable'

Breast cancer is curable if detected early, says Dr. Col. C.S. Pant (Retd), VSM, Head of Radiology Dept, Fortis La Femme.

During a woman's lifetime, a lot of changes occur in her breasts. While some changes are normal, others are not. Many women avoid learning about breast health or physiology unless they begin breastfeeding their children or they develop a problem that needs medical attention.

A woman's breasts are more complex than just a composition of fat. They consist of a complicated network of milk producing sacs, passageways for carrying milk, supporting tissue, lymph nodes, glands, tiny muscles and fat.

From puberty to menopause, not just the appearance of the breasts but also the composition and functioning of the breast tissue keeps changing with time. Breast Self Examination is, therefore, important for identifying Breast Cancer at a stage where it can be easily cured.

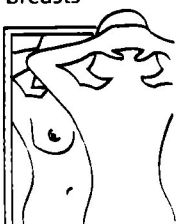
According to Dr. Pant, every woman from the age of 20 years and then for the rest of her life should do a breast examination on herself every month, immediately after her menstrual period (on the 8th day counting the first day of her period). At this time her estrogen levels are low, ensuring a more careful and accurate breast examination. While this is not always possible if breasts are swollen or tender, which is normal when estrogen levels are high.

To understand that you are doing it correctly, it is advisable to get a medical doctor or nurse to check out your technique.

Breast self-examination consists of three important steps:

Examining in front of a mirror

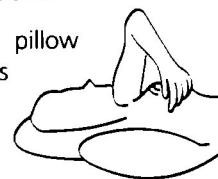
- Begin by looking at your breasts in a well-illuminated mirror with your shoulders straight and your arms on your hips. Carefully examine the usual size, shape and colour of breasts. Study your nipples carefully to ensure that they are not drawn up into the breasts and that the skin surrounding them is not red or dimpled, the pores not enlarged or coarse and there is no rash or scaling.
- Then place both hands on your hips and push them down, making sure that the chest muscles contract the same amount on either side. See that the skin does not dimple when you apply pressure while pressing down.
- Press your palms together at heart level and then raise them above your head. Pay attention to ensure that your skin does not dimple and the muscles are contracting evenly.
- Finally squeeze both nipples gently between your



forefinger and thumb, one at a time and look for any discharge. There may be some discharge after the birth of a baby or due to hormonal levels. However, anything unusual should be reported to a medical professional.

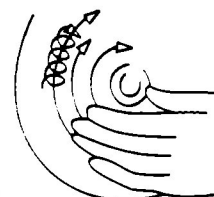
Examining the breasts while lying down

- Lie down comfortably with a pillow tucked under the shoulders and one hand raised behind the head. The position must ensure that the breast tissue spreads out over the rib cage making it easier to feel deep tissue layers with the fingers.
- Feel your breasts while lying down. Use your right hand to feel your left breast and then your left hand to feel your right breast.
- Use a firm, smooth touch with the first few fingers of your hand, keeping the fingers flat and together.
- Examine your breast from the collarbone, around the entire breast, around the nipple, down to the chest, and then all the way till under the arm.
- Repeat the same process with other breast.



Examining the breasts while sitting or standing

- Feel your breasts while you are standing or sitting. Many women find that the easiest way to feel their breasts is when they are having a shower. The soap and water enable the easy movement of hands over the breasts.
- Examine your breasts one at a time. If you're starting with your right breast, raise your right arm, place your right hand behind your head, and use your left hand to feel your breast.
- Think of your breast as a circle. Move your fingers in a spiral motion from the outside to the inside of the circle, gradually getting closer to the nipple, noticing what feels normal and what may feel different from the last time you examined your breasts.
- Use different levels of pressure - light, medium, and firm. This will allow you to feel the various layers of tissue in the breast. Start with light pressure, increase to medium pressure, and finish with firm pressure to feel the deepest tissue.
- Then put your left arm behind your head and check your left breast the same way.



While regular breast self - examination is recommended, it is advisable that you consult your doctor who may prescribe a diagnostic mammogram test.

